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THE LOST WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS

By

E. M. Sheridan

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San Nicolas Island is not classified as one of the Channel Islands, but belongs to what navigators term Cortez' Shoal. The Islands in the Channel group are San Miguel, Santa Rosa, Santa Cruz, San Clemente and San Nicolas, and also included is what is known as John Begg's Rock, seven miles northward from the northern extremity between Catalina and San Nicolas.

It is with San Nicolas that this article has to deal and because of the wonderful story of the Indian woman who was left alone on the Island in the thirties and who subsisted there for eighteen years following. San Nicolas lies eighty miles southward from Ventura and the mainland and nearly as many miles from any other land of presentable size, the nearest being the island of Santa Catalina, sixty miles away. In dimension it is about one-third the size of Santa Catalina. It has springs of water on it, is reasonably well watered by winter rains and will support several thousand head of sheep. It is wind-swept and at times large sections of it are covered with shifting sands. It is about nine miles in diameter.

There has been much written of the Indian woman who was left on the Island and much, of course, that was not true. According to the best authorities the island in its earlier days sustained a large Indian population. The story begins with the removal of a number of Indian women from the island in 1836. According to John Nidever, who was an uncle of the late Jacob Nidever of Ventura County

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and others who hunted otter about the island as early as 1835, the Alaska Indians were in the habit of making periodic visits to the islands for otter and other skins, with their Russian masters. They were savage people, the Alaskan Kadiacs, and made fierce attacks against all who attempted otter hunting on any of the islands. They were supplied with firearms and were dangerous foes even to the white men who were as well armed, and much more so to the natives, who had only bows and arrows and stone implements of warfare. In 1836 a party of these Indians who were left on the islands by a Russian vessel, chased Nidever and his party to their landing, and were only repulsed by a sharp fire which killed several of their men. The chase was on the water in boats, and the contest was in trying to prevent them landing at the only practicable place.

According to the best authority a part of these Indians took possession of San Nicolas island for the purpose of hunting otter, and finally took possession of the women, and slew every man and male child on the island, in the massacre that ensued. When the Alaskans abandoned San Nicolas, after the hunt was over, they left the women to their fate. It was some years subsequent to this that the padres employed men on the mainland to go to the island and remove the survivors.

Recent investigations made of the island and those things left by the residents of the islands shows that the former inhabitants were of the Toltec or Aztec races, and hence, it is said came the white skin and pleasant manner of the rescued Indian woman. The following is the story as told in an early day by Nidever, the man who finally rescued the woman:

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Story of the Rescue by Nidever.

I arrived on the coast in 1834, in the month of November. In the early part of the following year, 1835, I came to Santa Barbara and engaged in otter hunting, which I have followed almost uninterruptedly until within a few years. (This statement was made in the early seventies.) At the beginning of 1835 Isaac J. Sparks and Lewis T. Burton, Americans, also otter hunters, settled here and chartered the schooner "Peores-Nada," (worse than nothing) for the trip to the lower California coast. The schooner was commanded by Chas. Hubbard, who was hired by the owner of the schooner, a Spaniard at Monterey. The crew placed in her by Sparks, and Burton was, with two or three exceptions composed of Kanakas, natives of Hawaii. The "Peores-Nada" left Santa Barbara the latter part of April, 1835. About three months after she returned to San Pedro and from there went directly to the island of San Nicolas for the purpose of taking off the Indians then living there. Sparks, who hunted with me several years afterwards, told me the story, but I cannot now recollect who authorized or caused their removal. I remember distinctly, however, that man by the name of Williams, a former acquaintance of mine in the Rocky Mountains, took an interest and was one of the party that assisted in the removal. Also a man from Los Angeles was of the party. The circumstance of leaving the woman alone on the island was, as near as I can recollect, from what Sparks told me, as follows:

REMOVAL OF THE INDIANS

Having got all the Indians together on the beach and ready for embarking, one of them made signs that her child had been left behind, whereupon she was allowed to go back and fetch it. She was

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gone some time, when a strong wind springing up, they did not dare to wait longer for her, fearing for the safety of the schooner.

The water, which is quite shoal about the island, becomes exceedingly rough in a storm, and there is no harbor of any kind that would afford shelter in a heavy gale. They ran before the wind and reached San Pedro in safety. Here the Indians were put ashore, some being taken to Los Angeles and some to the Mission of San Gabriel. It was the intention of the captain of the schooner to return for the woman who had been left on the island, as soon as possible. From San Pedro the "Peores-Nada" came direct to Santa Barbara, took Sparks and myself over to Santa Rosa island, and then sailed for Monterey, where she had been ordered to take a cargo of lumber to San Francisco. At the entrance to the Golden Gate the "Peores-Nada" capsized and her crew were washed ashore. It was afterwards reported that the schooner drifted out to sea and was picked up by a Russian vessel, though this report was never confirmed. There were now no craft of any kind larger than the Indian canoe, and the boats of the otter hunters, left on the coast, in the Southern waters, and none cared to attempt the passage of the channel to San Nicolas in an open boat. It was soon known throughout the coast that an Indian woman was left on the island. But so far as I can learn no attempt was ever made to rescue her. As the years passed by all thought that she had perished.

VISIT SHOWS SIGNS OF LIFE.

In 1851 I had occasion to visit San Nicolas island. I found signs that led me to believe that the woman still survived or that a human being was living upon the island. I had with me a man named Tom Jeffries. He and I, with one of the Indian crew landed near the

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lower end of the island and walked along the beach, and on the bank, close to the beach, for a distance of five or six miles. Soon after starting out we found the footprints of a human being, that, in all probability, had been made during the previous rainy season. They were distinctly defined, and for their size we concluded that they were those of a woman. We also discovered three small circular enclosures, about 200 yards back from the beach, something like a mile apart, six or seven feet in diameter, with walls perhaps five or six feet high, made of brush. Near these huts, or enclosures, there were stakes of driftwood stuck in the ground, and suspended upon them, at a height of five or six feet, were pieces of dried blubber, which had the appearance of having been placed there within a month or two, as they still in a good state of preservation. With these exceptions there was nothing about the enclosures, or windbreaks, as I would call them, that indicated that they had been occupied for years. We had come ashore early in the morning, and, after finding the footprints and wind-breaks, we intended to make further search, but before noon a strong wind sprung up, and we hastened back to the schooner. We were hardly on board when the wind increased to a gale and continued to blow for about eight days, so strong at times that we expected to be blown out to sea. We were on the south side of the island, or under its lee, and in a measure protected from the wind, but the sea was so rough that we found it almost impossible to remain at anchor. Once our anchor dragged and we were compelled to improvise a second by filling a bag with stone. The eighth day, the wind having gone down, we were enabled to leave the island.

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NARRATOR MAKES SECOND VISIT

In the winter of 1852 I made a second trip to the island for otter, having seen large number of otter on my previous trip. On this trip I was accompanied by Charles Brown. We landed, as on our former visit, at the lower end of the island. We took two Indians ashore with us and left them in charge of the boat, while Brown and I walked along the Beach, towards the head of the island. We went partly to see where the otter lay, and partly to see if we could find any sign of the Indian woman, as Father Gonzales, to whom we had reported the discoveries made on our former visit, assured us that there was no longer any doubt of her being alive. We had decided to go to the head of the island, as, for various reasons, we concluded that if she was alive she would be most likely to be found there. The water is better and more abundant there, and it is a better place for both fish and seal. We visited the huts that Jeffries had discovered and found them and their surroundings unchanged, except that it seemed to me that the seal blubber, which I had seen on my former visit, had been removed and fresh blubber hung in its place.

In the neighborhood of the huts near the shore we saw seven or eight wild dogs. They were about the size and form of a coyote, of a black and white color. I have seen the same kind of dogs among the northwest Indians. They were very wild and ran off as soon as they saw us. When within about a half mile of the head of the island we saw a low, sandy flat that extended from one side of the island to the other. Here, we thought, in all probability, she must be living, as the ground to the north and east of this flat was high and exposed

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to the wind. After searching around for some time and finding no sign of her, we were about to return, having concluded that the dogs must have eaten her, as not even her bones were to be found, when I discovered in the crotch of a bush or small tree, a basket, and upon throwing off the piece of seal skin that covered it, we found within, carefully laid together a dress made of shag skins cut in square pieces, a rope made of sinew, and several small articles, such as abalone fish-hooks, bone needles, etc.

After examining them Brown proposed replacing them and returning the basket to the tree where we found it, but I scattered the contents upon the ground, telling him that if upon our return we should find them replaced in the basket it would be positive proof of the woman's existence. As it was now quite late we returned to the schooner, intending to renew the search at the first opportunity, as the extreme head of the island was still unexplored by us. For the next few days, however, we were busy hunting otter, and about the fourth or fifth day a southeast wind began to blow, which soon increased to a gale. We waited about six or seven days for it to go down and then, with some difficulty, we ran over to the San Miguel Island.

DISCOVERY OF THE WOMAN

I next fitted out a hut on San Nicolas in July, 1853. My crew consisted of Charles Brown, one Irishman and four Mission Indians. This time I went with the intention of making a thorough search for the missing woman. We arrived off the island in the early part of the day and anchored opposite the middle of the southeast side about 10:00 A.M. Brown and I went on shore to see where the otter lay and to

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select a suitable camping place. We left two of our Indians in charge of the boat. We then kept along the shore without finding any signs of the Indian woman, until we reached the head of the island. Here I sat down to rest while Brown went around the head of the island. and down some distance on the other side. When he returned he told me that he had seen fresh tracks of the Indian woman and had followed them from the beach up over the bank, but on the side of the ridge that formed the head of the island he had lost them, the ground being covered with moss. I was at first disposed to think that our men from the schooner had gone over there, but a moment's reflection convinced me that it would be impossible for them to get in advance of us, and besides, Brown said the tracks were too small to have been made by either of our men.

It was now getting late and we returned on board with the determination of making the next day a thorough exploration of the upper portion of the island. Accordingly, after breakfast next morning, we started with all of our men except the cook. Reaching the low, sand flat before mentioned Brown and the four men stretched out in a line and crossed to the other side of the island, while I continued along near the shore, on the same side I had come, towards the head of the island. Brown and his men made no discoveries in passing over the island. He then sent the men back to search along the border of the sand flat and among the bushes where the basket had been found. He went up towards the head on that side until he struck the track he had seen the night before. He followed it up again until he found a short piece of driftwood. From this he concluded she had been down to the beach for fire-wood, and had dropped this piece on her way. From this point he saw further up the ridge the three huts. Upon reaching them

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he found them made of whale ribs, covered with brush, although they were open on all sides. The grass was quite high within them showing that no one had occupied them for some time. He was now on one of the highest parts of the ridge, and he began to look about in all directions. The sandy flat was in plain sight and he could see most of the men. At last his eye caught sight of a small black object a long distance off that seemed to be moving. It looked at first very much like a crow. Walking towards it he soon found that it was the Indian woman. She was seated in an inclosure similar to those already described, so that her head and shoulders were barely visible above it. As he approached her two or three dogs, like those we had seen before, close to her, began to growl. Without looking in the direction of Brown she gave a yell and the dogs disappeared. Brown had halted within a few yards of her, and once began to signal to the men by placing a hat on the ramrod of his gun and raising and lowering it. He soon succeeded in attracting their attention and they came towards him. In the meantime Brown had an opportunity of observing the woman. She was seated, cross-legged, upon some grass which covered the enclosure on the inside and which no doubt served as a bed. Her only dress was a kind of gown, leaving her neck and shoulders bare, and long enough, when she stood up to reach to her ankles. It was made of shag skins, cut in squares and sewed together, the feathers being pointed downward. Her head had no cover save a thick mass of matted hair of a yellowish-brown color, probably from the exposure to the sun and weather, and which looked as if it might have rotted off. She was engaged in stripping the blubber from a piece of seal skin which she held across one knee, using in the operation a rude knife made of a piece of iron hoop.

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Within the enclosure was a smoldering fire, and without a large pile of ashes, and another of bones, which would indicate that this had been her abode for a long time. From the time Brown first arrived within hearing distance she kept up a continual talking to herself, occasionally shading her eyes with her hands and gazing steadily at the men who were seen walking around on the flat below. She was evidently much interested in their movements. As the men came near Brown motioned them spread out so as to prevent her escape if she was so disposed. Just before the men reached her camp Brown, who had not been seen by her, came around in front.

RECEIVES HER COMPANY WITH DIGNITY

To his great surprise she received them with much dignity and politeness, bowing and smiling with ease and self-possession. As fast as the men came up she greeted each in the same way. The men seated themselves on the ground around, the woman all the time talking, although not a word of hers could be understood, although our Indians spoke several dialects. From a sack or bag made of grass she took some roots, known among the Californians as the Carcomites, and another root whose name I did not learn, and placed them in the fire. When they were roasted she offered them to us to eat. We found them very palatable, indeed. We were now desirous of taking her on board the shhooner. We did not apprehend that she would try to escape, as she seemed much pleased with our company. We commenced making signs for her to go with us, but she seemed unable to comprehend them until we intimated that she must gather up all her food, when she set about the work with the greatest alacrity, and commenced putting them in a large basket, such as is in general use among the Indians of the coast. She considerable dried blubber of the seal and sea elephant

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This was all carefully collected. There was also a seal's head, in such a decayed condition that the brains were oozing out. At her desire this also was taken along.

She seemed desirous of preserving everything that would sustain life, thus indicating the sad experience of her eighteen years of solitude. When all was ready she took a burning stick in one hand or on her shoulders. She trotted along merrily, leading us to a spring of good water, which came out under a shelving rock near the beach. Here we found a store of bones in a cleft of the rocks. It would seem that in time of scarcity she would come here and suck the bones as long as any nutriment could be obtained from them. Here also were pieces of dried blubber hung on stakes, above the reaches of the foxes and dogs which inhabited the island. We gained the woman's confidence by taking care to preserve all these articles. On the way to the schooner she led us past another spring, which she seemed to have used for bathing, as she stopped and washed her hands and face. This spring was not far from the landing. When we reached the boat we made motion for her to step in, which she did, kneeling down in the bow, holding to the sides with her hands. When we got on the vessel she sought the vicinity of the stove, keeping as near to it as possible, which indicated her bitter experience on the island.

We offered her some of our food, which she ate with relish; in fact, from this time she seemed to prefer our style of food to her own. Brown went to work that afternoon and made her a skirt, or a petticoat out of some bed-ticking, with which she was much pleased, continually calling our attention to it. This skirt, with a man's shirt and neck-tie, constituted her new wardrobe. While Brown was

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sewing she made signs that she wanted to sew, and Brown gave her a needle and thread. After this was done by one of us she knew how to use it. I gave her an old cloak, or heavy cape, which was much torn and dilapidated. She patiently sewed up all the rents and made it quite servicable in the cold, windy weather which prevailed occasionally. In sewing she thrust the needle into the cloth with her right hand and pulled it through, drawing the thread tightly with her left hand.

IN THE OTTER HUNTERS' CAMP

The following day we moved on shore and made a camp on a narrow piece of ground between the beach and the rocks, and made a shelter by leaning some poles against the rocks and covering them with sail cloth. We made a similar shelter for her at a short distance, covering it with brush. We remained on the island hunting otter about a month. During the time she evinced no disposition to leave, but was generally talking, singing and wandering about the island. She assisted in the camp work, bringing wood and water when it was needed. Her vessels for carrying water were quite unique.

They were woven of grass, shaped somewhat like a demijohn, except that they had wider mouths, and were lined with a thin coating of asphaltum. The process of lining them was rather ingenious. She put several pieces of asphaltum, which is found in great quantities along the beach, in the bottom of the basket or receptacle, and then on top of them some hot pebbles. When the asphaltum was melted by the pebbles, by a quick rotary motion, she would cover the inside of the receptacle with an even coating, after which the surplus, with pebbles, were thrown out. These bas ets were water-tight and would

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last a long time. She had several of these water vessels in process of construction when we found her. She would work at one a few minutes, abandon it, and try another. I am not aware that she ever completed one when with us. When we killed otter we usually, after skinning them, threw the bodies into the sea. One day we killed a large female, which was with young. When about to cast it into the sea, as usual, she in her mute way, protested. The young one, which was nearly grown and covered with fur, was taken out and the skin stuffed and made to look quite natural, by one of the party. She took a great fancy to the baby otter, and suspended it to a pole of her shelter, would swing it back and forth for hours, talking to it in a kind of sing-song tone.

REMOVED TO THE MAINLAND

After hunting successfully about a month we put everything on the schooner and sailed for Santa Barbara. Not long after sailing a furious gale arose, which threatened to engulf the little vessel. The woman made signs that she would allay the wind, and kneeling down, facing the quarter whence the wind came, she began making incantations, or prayers, which she continued for some time, and at intervals during the storm. When the wind abated she pointed with triumph to the clear sky, as much as to say: "See what I did." We approached the shore early in the morning. It was evident that she had never seen it before, or any of the ordinary sights of a settlement. An Ox team, with a Spanish cart, passed on the sand. It is not known whether it was pleasure or won^{der} which passed through her mind. The yoke which tied the animals to each other and to the cart; the uncouth wheels, with their rotary motion, which she imitated with various gestures, were

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inexpressibly wonderful, delightful, and ludicrous. She laughed, talked, gesticulated all at once. After our landing a horseman, among others, came to the beach. This was a new creature, also, but she had the courage to examine it, touching horse and man in succession. She turned to her friends, for so may be considered her captors, and straddled the first two fingers of her right hand over her left thumb, and imitating the galloping of a horse with her fingers, gave shouts of delight. Ashore she was taken to Nidever's house and put in care of his wife.

GREATEST INTEREST IN THE WOMAN

The story soon spread that the lost woman of San Nicolas was found. The possibility of there being a woman alive alone on a desert island in the ocean, with only wild animals for companions, had been discussed in many households, and who was now in the midst of such warm-hearted people was a subject of intense interest. As the years had passed and nothing was heard of her the general conclusion was that she had perished, probably devoured by the wild animals on the island. The fathers of the Mission had exerted themselves in the matter and had offered a reward of \$200 dollars for information that would lead to her discovery. When Nidever had reported finding tracks on the island, and other evidences of life, Father Gonzales had confidently asserted that she was alive, and her coming back to the mainland and life at last aroused the greatest interest everywhere the news penetrated.

Hundreds flocked to Nidever's house. Among others came Father Gonzales, Sanchez and Jimeno. Though familiar with all the dialects of the Indians, of the coast not a word of her language could be under-

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stood. Indians from Santa Ynez, Los Angeles and other places were brought, with no better success; not one of them understood a word of her language. She soon became very expert in conversing by signs, however, and continued to tell portions of her story, so that but little uncertainty attended the narrative. She related that when she went back after her child she wandered a long time without finding it; then she concluded that the dogs had eaten the child and she laid down a long time and became sick, and could not eat anything and got around again and began to eat. She had often seen vessels on the sea, but none of them ever came to take her away. She finally became reconciled to her fate and commenced the routine of life which was to be varied only by hunger, thirst, cold and fear of wild animals for near a score of years.

She was received with the utmost kindness. Almost everyone made her a present of money, clothing, or trinkets, which, however, she would immediately give to her friends or to the children who came to see her. In all those days the Panama steamers used to touch at Santa Barbara, and always all the passengers were desirous of seeing the lost woman. She would often put on her finest dress of feathers and go through the movements which the people termed dancing though it had little resemblance to the graceful dances of the ballroom. She became very much attached to the family, which feeling was mutual, for Nidever several times refused large sums which offered to have her exhibited to the public of San Francisco.

She was thought to be about fifty years of age at the time she was found. As near as could be made out by her signs she had, at the time of being left on the island, two children, one of which was a nursing

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babe, the other some years older, though in the opinion of some the elder child had died some years previously. She had a smooth face, though the skin on her body was much wrinkled. It was but a short time before her death that they succeeded in making her understand their desire to have some words of her own language. The following are about all that were learned of it: A hide she called "tocah"; man, "nache"; the sky, "toygwah"; the body, "puoo-chay".

She was like a child in every respect as to her appetite, having no control whatever. She was excessively fond of fruit, which she would eat at all hazards. It produced a dysentary, which in spite of careful nursing and attendance, terminated fatally in about four weeks. During her sickness it was thought that a diet of seal's meat, such as she had been accustomed to, would relieve her. Some was procured and roasted, but she shook her head and laughed, and rubbed her fingers along her worn-out teeth, signifying that they were too old. She was buried by the Mission fathers and most of her island trinkets and her shag feather dresses were sent to Rome and found a place in the Vatican museum.

In conclusion, we can but question ourselves, What kept this lone woman's heart warm through all her long years of solitude, with no companions but those wild Russian dogs? When found at last she was as blythe and sunny as a child, with a heart still as warm as that of any child, with love and gratitude for her deliverance at last, and again, why that other, her best dress? Why was it? We will ask ourselves these things, perhaps, but who can answer to the mysteries in the realms of woman nature?